

HIGH TURNOUT
Women voters in Bhopal during the 2019 general election

PANKAJ TIWARI

the fact that they number 357,499 in 45,527 of Madhya Pradesh's 51,527 villages, and allow free access to about 4.6 million families.

Besides the SHGs, funding for Chouhan's pet CM Kanya Vivah Yojana has been hiked as well, with the amount payable to the beneficiary increased from Rs 51,000 to Rs 55,000 this year. There are upwards of 40 schemes that are women-specific, including a new one introduced this budget that will provide e-scooties to girl students who secure a first division in their Class 12 exams. Total spending on women in the budget is estimated at Rs 1.03 lakh crore.

"If there is one demographic that Shivraj Singh Chouhan has singly focused on in elections, it is women," says Girija Shankar, a political analyst. "Even before he became CM, through his mass marriage ceremonies, Chouhan knew about the potential of this voting bloc. He has continued this trend and is making it an election issue. There are decent chances of this bringing BJP political dividends if implemented well."

Chouhan's government has also hiked spending on sites associated with the Hindu religion. However, even in that, the CM has women voters in sight. "Women are a large part of religious functions. Look at any site in MP with substantial devotee footfall, be it Mahakal in Ujjain or Salkanpur in Sehore district, women are present in large numbers," says a BJP functionary, explaining the twin objectives behind the move.

"The new scheme will click because of its universal appeal as it is not based on any one caste or community," says veteran journalist N.K. Singh. "The BJP also knows how to package such schemes and derive benefits from it. Caste will remain a factor in the polls but women-centric schemes have the potential to blunt the benefit of caste that the other party is deriving."

While Chouhan has revealed his cards, how is the Congress planning to counter its benefits? Soon after the BJP announced LBY, the Congress, too, announced a Mahila Sashakti Yojana under which Rs 1,500 would be paid monthly to women beneficiaries. The party's other announcements benefit not just women but the entire family in general. "While women empowerment is great, the bitter truth is that a large number of men still decide who the women in the family will vote for," says a Congress leader not wishing to be named lest he be pulled up for voicing a 'regressive' viewpoint. Consequently, the Congress has announced schemes that will ease the household expenses affecting both men and women. Among them is subsiding the LPG cylinder by Rs 500, restoration of the old pension scheme (OPS) and a flat Rs 100 electricity bill per month for certain income categories. Congress insiders claim that after the filters that have been introduced in LBY, the number of beneficiaries will drop to around 450,000-500,000, reducing its impact. "We are working on a women-centric manifesto, which will be released in due time. In the Congress, schemes are announced after due consultation from workers on the ground unlike the BJP where schemes come from the top," says Piyush Babele, media coordinator for PCC president and former chief minister Kamal Nath.

Crucially, for Chouhan to derive political mileage from his schemes, delivery is a key imperative. A lot will depend on the bureaucracy in the villages and towns involved in the registration for LBY. Singh points to another danger. "Any allegation of corruption in the implementation will be a setback to Chouhan's efforts to derive political mileage." Weak delivery or any whiff of corruption could prove to be the undoing of the Chouhan government and upset the very vote bank he is trying to woo. ■